



Devil's Tower

A 40-million-year-old massive domed monolith in Wyoming with columnar fluting on its sides

Devil's Tower is one of the most iconic U.S. landmarks. Often referred to as a butte (an isolated hill with vertical sides and a small, flat top), its exact origins are debated—in particular, whether or not it formed inside a volcano. However, experts agree that it started off as a mass of magma that cooled and solidified underground. In the process, remarkably uniform polygonal columns formed in the cooling body, and this fluting is still visible today.

Regarded as a sacred spot by Native Americans, in 1906, it became the first site in the U.S. to be declared a National Monument. It is also famous as the location for a climactic meeting between humans and visitors from space in the 1977 film *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*.

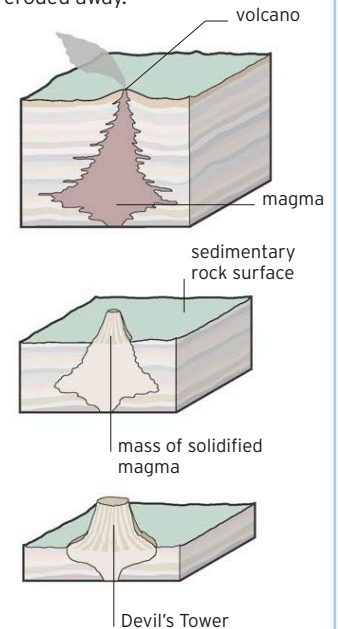


△ STANDING TALL

Devil's Tower rises 866 ft (264 m) from its rocky base to its relatively flat top, which is about the size of a football field.

HOW DEVIL'S TOWER FORMED

One theory about the formation of Devil's Tower suggests that a volcano formed, and later, some magma within the volcano solidified into a hard mass. This was exposed as the tower when surrounding rock layers were eroded away.



The Appalachians

A complex and highly scenic series of mountain ranges, stretching from Alabama to southeastern Canada



The Appalachians are the eroded remnants of an ancient mountain belt that formed about 500 million years ago through collisions between ancient continents. Over the last 65 million years, the whole belt has been uplifted and eroded to what is seen today—a vast area of gently

rounded, mostly forested hills and mountains. It consists of many parallel provinces (see panel, below), including the Blue Ridge Mountains, noted for a bluish haze when seen from a distance. The color is in part due to a chemical released into the air by trees in the region.

▽ FALL PALETTE

In fall, foliage creates an explosion of color across the Appalachians, as seen here in the White Mountains range in the northern Appalachians.

INSIDE THE APPALACHIANS

This west-to-east cross-section through the central part of the Appalachians shows folding, faults, and ridges. It also shows the provinces into which the whole belt is split.

